

Chapter 5

Conclusion

In conclusion, d'Indy engages in extensive theoretical discussions about the genesis and evolution of musical ideas, outlining concepts such as generative periods. His theories demonstrate a preference for homogeneity and dualistic structures, analyzing musical differences through binary categories like gender, specifically "masculine" versus "feminine" themes. He also employs numerical methods to generalize structural organization. These approaches are not purely about form—they connect with broader cultural and ideological convictions, including his recorded views on race and nationalism.



Yet, when it comes to actual analysis, d'Indy often sets these broader principles aside, allowing the details of the piece to shape his interpretation rather than forcing the music to conform to his theoretical constructs.

During d'Indy's era, theoretical approaches to music were characterized by a broad scope of abstraction, where theories could encompass a wide range of musical phenomena, often without strict boundaries. This allowed theorists to explore and articulate musical principles in a more expansive and sometimes speculative manner. In contrast, contemporary music theory has become increasingly specialized, focusing on more narrowly defined areas of study. This specialization reflects a significant paradigm shift in the field, where the emphasis is now on depth rather than breadth, applying rigorous methodologies to specific aspects of music.

Given these contrasting methodologies, we can view d'Indy's and Caplin's theo-

ries as representing two distinct discourses, as exemplified in my comparative analysis. While d'Indy's theory can offer valuable insights into Caplin's framework, it does not directly replace or function as a fully developed alternative. Instead, d'Indy's ideas serve as complementary perspectives that help inform and refine Neo-Caplinian approaches, rather than standing as a substitute.



But has music theory truly transformed so completely? Despite criticisms that place d'Indy's work in an old-fashioned theoretical discourse, there are moments where his methods appear remarkably avant-garde. His comprehensive walkthroughs of Beethoven's sonatas and symphonies reveal a proto-structural approach that foreshadows aspects of modern corpus studies, demonstrating a forward-thinking methodology that aligns with current analytical trends.

Furthermore, beyond his existential discussion, in analyzing "Hammerklavier," d'Indy's approach is firmly rooted in the descriptive details of a specific musical example. The analytical part, somewhat segregated from his broader theoretical discussions, resulting in a focus on labeling and categorizing sections without attempting to draw strong arguments. The overall tone, filled with descriptions, resembles a flat, almost scientific publication, lacking the rhetorical embellishment or grand interpretative statements often found in more theory-driven texts.

In contrast, Caplin's analysis of the Hammerklavier is clearly theory-driven, aiming to illustrate an extreme case of an expanded cadential progression, even if doing so places his interpretation at the fringes of the broader scholarly consensus and occasionally stretches the framework's applicability to fit the piece.

Addressing the issue of disciplinary focus, Joseph Kerman remarks,

In fact, it seems to me that the true intellectual milieu of analysis is not science but ideology. [Kerman, 1980, p. 314]

Caplin's approach, then, seems to fall into a form of interpretive bias, driven by the need to validate his theoretical model of expanded cadential progression. Whether these analytical claims are empirically grounded or not, they are shaped by an underlying preference for a particular interpretive lens. A parallel can be

drawn to d'Indy's use of the number three: although numbers are ostensibly neutral and measurable, choosing specific numerical patterns to represent musical form and assigning them symbolic significance are subjective acts influenced by broader conceptual beliefs.

Caplin's theory, developed and popularized through his textbooks, is heavily example-based, but it is still shaped by certain selective choices and constraints. Developed from the classical repertoire of Haydn, Mozart, and *early* Beethoven, this analytical framework may struggle when applied to Beethoven's late compositions, where its effectiveness diminishes, leading to more disagreement among scholars.

Moreover, the harmony in the "Hammerklavier" presents additional issues. As illustrated in 4.3, the harmonic rhythm accelerates, reflecting a Romantic style, which, according to Caplin, deviates from the classical harmonic syntax [Caplin, 2018]. This shift questions the applicability of Caplin's classical cadential models in the context of late Beethoven. Melodic content could potentially be more reliable as reference for determining formal section, as did Vincent d'Indy.

Consequently, for analyzing Beethoven's late work, a relatively independent analytical needs to be adopted, like d'Indy's one. His chapter uses "Hammerklavier" as a starting point, demonstrates a more adaptable framework for analyzing late Beethovenian work.

Yet he also stumbles by choosing a piece that is not truly representative of Beethoven's output. The Hammerklavier Sonata, with its massive scale and complexity, is an outlier, and using it to substantiate d'Indy's theories risks overfitting his analytical model to a single, highly atypical work. This choice limits the broader applicability of his ideas, making it difficult to generalize his framework to more standard Beethovenian forms. For instance, while d'Indy categorizes the Hammerklavier's transition into three distinct elements, he struggles to maintain similar degree of complexity in subsequent analyses, such as Beethoven's 5th Symphony, where his labeling reduces the transition to just four measures.

In his *Cours de composition*, d'Indy jumps from pre-Beethovenian sonatas to

Beethoven's late works, using pieces like the Hammerklavier Sonata, which features a fugal development section—an unconventional occurrence even within Beethoven's own sonatas. Using such a monumental and atypical piece to substantiate his theories introduces an overly complex angle, raising the question: does it genuinely bridge the gap between the works of Beethoven's predecessors and his own highly evolved structures? Addressing this gap by analyzing more transitional works could provide valuable insights into how d'Indy's theoretical framework might be adapted or extended to bridge the stylistic and formal evolution from early sonata forms to Beethoven's mature compositions.

Finally, given d'Indy's engagement in music pedagogy, this raises a critical question: is this redundancy reflective of his teaching philosophy? Does his pedagogy fall into a similar trap of focusing on the most complex and extreme examples, leaving students equipped only for exceptional cases while lacking the tools to handle more conventional ones? If so, his methodology might produce students who are highly skilled at dissecting intricate pieces but struggle to apply these techniques to standard repertoire, creating a disconnect between theory and practical utility. Exploring whether d'Indy's teaching approach shows similar tendencies would open up new avenues for understanding the strengths and potential limitations of his broader pedagogical framework.